nearby, interacts with groups of people or addresses press meets. At 4.30 pm, the second round of the walk begins, which often continues well past sundown. While he walks, the containers shift base to the end point of the day's march.

In the evening, he addresses public meetings, at times braving downpours—giving his party members and enthusiasts some iconic photo memories to plaster all over social media. Those spaces have been awash with images of him smiling, chatting, waving, hugging overjoyed commoners, taking little children in his arms, making local party grandees go on short sprints with him—at the head of a billowing comet's tail of followers. They are seen to fill up highways in impressive drone shots and slick videos embellished with rousing marching songs. The day's engagements over, Rahul returns to the container camp, has dinner, and is often in a huddle with senior Congress leaders strategising for the next day. Finally, he retreats to his container, reads a book or remains engrossed with his mobile phone till he catches sleep well past midnight. This is the daily drill Rahul has been following in his padayatra from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, criss-crossing 11 states and one Union territory. The yatra's name names its own high objective: uniting India.

Dressed in a white T-shirt, trousers and sneakers, the Gandhi scion will go through this rigour for the next four months—having finished just one. By Day 157, the yatra is to have completed all of 3,570 km. It's a journey intent on its own progress: Rahul may not even take a break to campaign in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, scheduled to go to polls in a couple of months. In fact, the BJY is not even covering the two states. In the rationalising, if evasive words of Congress leaders, this exercise is 'not about winning elections'. They speak of building a narrative of unity against the BJP's divisive politics and raising issues that affect common citizens the most—price rise and unemployment. "The objective is not the 2024 election...in our political system, a distance has developed between the political class and our citizens. The idea of the Bharat Jodo Yatra is to go on the road and meet our people," Rahul said at a press conference in Karnataka.

On cue, he duly articulates local issues and pays obeisance to local sentiments—but isn't entirely oblivious to the demands of politics. In Karnataka, in almost every speech, he takes the name of Basava, the revered 12th-century social reformer from the state. And then reminds people how the Basavaraj Bommai-led BJP government in Karnataka is "the most corrupt in India". When it comes to naming a Congress chief ministerial candidate for the next assembly polls, he plays safe: "We have brilliant leaders in Karnataka and, once we win, the chief minister will be decided through a process that is carried out in the Congress party."

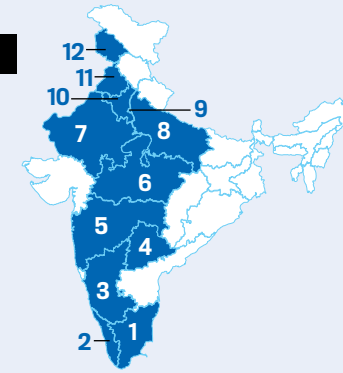
BHARAT JODO YATRA IN NUMBERS

THE GEOGRAPHY

3,570 KM
to be covered in 157 days

22 KM
Average daily walking distance

WALKING SCHEDULE
6.30 am to 11.30 am, and from 4.30 pm to 7 pm



STATES ON THE ROUTE
11 states and one UT
1. Tamil Nadu **2.** Kerala **3.** Karnataka
4. Telangana **5.** Maharashtra
6. Madhya Pradesh **7.** Rajasthan
8. Uttar Pradesh **9.** Delhi **10.** Haryana
11. Punjab **12.** Jammu and Kashmir

THE PEOPLE

123
permanent yatris, including Rahul Gandhi

35
Women yatris

38
Average age



YOUNGEST MEMBER
Vaishnavi G. Bhardwaj, 26, Nagpur



OLDEST MEMBER
Vijendra Singh Mahlawat, 58, Rajasthan



"MODI SPEAKS HIS *MANN KI BAAT*, RAHUL LISTENS TO PEOPLE'S *MANN KI BAAT*. THIS YATRA IS A DIRECT WAY TO LISTEN TO THE VOICE OF INDIA"

JAIRAM RAMESH
Rajya Sabha MP, Congress communications in-charge



"HE DOESN'T GET TIRED AT ALL EVEN THOUGH HE SLEEPS ONLY 4-5 HOURS AT NIGHT. I'M YET TO SEE A FITTER POLITICIAN IN INDIA"

RANDEEP SINGH SURJEWALA
Rajya Sabha MP, Congress gen. secy